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Zedekiah

*Judah's last king, who kept asking for God's word but never found the courage to obey it.*

Zedekiah was a son of good King Josiah. Nebuchadnezzar of Babylon put him on the throne after carrying his nephew Jehoiachin into exile, and even gave him his royal name. For eleven years he ruled a shrinking kingdom caught between Babylon and Egypt. Again and again he sent for Jeremiah and asked, in secret, whether there was any word from the LORD. There was, and it did not change: submit to Babylon and live. But Zedekiah feared his own officials more than he trusted God. He broke his oath to Nebuchadnezzar and rebelled. Jerusalem fell, the temple burned, and Zedekiah was blinded and led away to Babylon in chains.

At a glance

|               |                                                                   |
|---------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Name          | Born Mattaniah; renamed Zedekiah, "the LORD is righteous"         |
| Family        | Son of Josiah and Hamutal; uncle of Jehoiachin (2 Kings 24:17–18) |
| Reign         | 11 years from age 21, c. 597–586 BC                               |
| Key places    | Jerusalem, the plains of Jericho, Riblah, Babylon                 |
| Key people    | Jeremiah, Nebuchadnezzar, Ebed-melech, the princes of Judah       |
| Main passages | 2 Kings 24:17–25:7; Jeremiah 21; 27; 32–39                        |
| New Testament | Not named                                                         |

*"And he did that which was evil in the sight of the LORD his God, and humbled not himself before Jeremiah the prophet speaking from the mouth of the LORD."*

2 Chronicles 36:12, KJV

# The life of Zedekiah

Dates are approximate (BC) and agree with the Josiah and Jeremiah chapters. Some date the fall of Jerusalem to 587 BC. Scripture does not say when Zedekiah died.

**c. 597 BC**

Age 21

## ● Made king by Babylon

Nebuchadnezzar takes Jehoiachin to Babylon and makes his uncle Mattaniah king, changing his name to Zedekiah. He makes him swear by God to stay loyal. *2 Kings 24:15–18; 2 Chronicles 36:10–13*

**c. 594 BC**

4th year

## ● Tempted to rebel

Envoys from nearby kingdoms come to Jerusalem. Jeremiah wears a yoke and tells Zedekiah to serve the king of Babylon and live. *Jeremiah 27:3, 12–15; 28:1*

**c. 589 BC**

Late in his reign

## ● Rebels

Zedekiah breaks his oath and rebels against Nebuchadnezzar, apparently hoping for help from Egypt. *2 Kings 24:20; 2 Chronicles 36:13; Ezekiel 17:15*

**c. 588 BC**

9th year

## ● The siege begins

Nebuchadnezzar's army surrounds Jerusalem and builds siege works around it. *2 Kings 25:1; Jeremiah 39:1*

**c. 588–586 BC**

During the siege

## ● Secret meetings

Zedekiah asks Jeremiah privately for God's word and is told to surrender. He lets his officials throw Jeremiah into a cistern, then allows his rescue. *Jeremiah 37:16–21; 38:1–28*

**c. 586 BC**

11th year

## ● Flight and capture

Famine grips the city and the wall is broken. Zedekiah flees by night but is caught in the plains of Jericho. At Riblah his sons are killed before his eyes, and he is blinded. *2 Kings 25:2–7; Jeremiah 39:2–7*

**After c. 586 BC**

In Babylon

## ● Dies a prisoner

He is taken to Babylon in chains and kept in prison until the day of his death. *Jeremiah 52:11*

# Key activities

2 Kings 24:17 calls Zedekiah Jehoiachin's "father's brother," while 2 Chronicles 36:10 calls him his "brother," a word that can mean any close relative. Many scholars think Zedekiah's royal name echoes Jeremiah's promise of a coming king called "THE LORD OUR RIGHTEOUSNESS" (Jeremiah 23:5-6).

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- 1 Swore loyalty to Babylon.** He took an oath in God's name to serve Nebuchadnezzar. *2 Chronicles 36:13; Ezekiel 17:13*
  - 2 Sent to inquire of the LORD.** He asked Jeremiah to pray for the city and to ask whether God would save it. *Jeremiah 21:1-2; 37:3*
  - 3 Freed the slaves, then took them back.** He led Jerusalem in a covenant to free Hebrew slaves, but the owners soon took them back. *Jeremiah 34:8-11*
  - 4 Asked in secret.** He brought Jeremiah from prison and asked, "Is there any word from the LORD?" *Jeremiah 37:17*
  - 5 Gave way to his officials.** He handed Jeremiah over to the princes, who put him in a cistern. *Jeremiah 38:4-6*
  - 6 Feared people more than God.** He admitted he was afraid of the Jews who had gone over to the Babylonians. *Jeremiah 38:19-20*
  - 7 Rebelled and fled.** He broke his oath, and when the city fell he ran and was captured. *2 Kings 24:20-25:6*
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## Group notes

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# Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links, not places that name Zedekiah.

## Old Testament

|                                                  |                                                    |
|--------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------|
| <b>2 Kings 24:17–25:7; 2 Chronicles 36:10–21</b> | His reign and Jerusalem's fall                     |
| <b>Jeremiah 21; 27; 32–39; 52</b>                | Jeremiah's many dealings with him                  |
| <b>Jeremiah 34:4–5</b>                           | Promised death in peace, not by the sword          |
| <b>Ezekiel 12:12–13</b>                          | Brought to Babylon, "yet shall he not see it"      |
| <b>Ezekiel 17:11–21</b>                          | The parable of two eagles condemns his broken oath |
| <b>Echo: 1 Samuel 15:24</b>                      | Saul also feared the people and disobeyed          |

## New Testament

|                         |                                                 |
|-------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Matthew 1:11–12</b>  | The carrying away to Babylon, in Jesus' line    |
| <b>Echo: James 1:22</b> | "Be ye doers of the word, and not hearers only" |
| <b>Echo: Mark 15:15</b> | Pilate knew the right thing but gave way        |

### For discussion

- Observe:* What question did Zedekiah ask Jeremiah, and what was the answer (Jeremiah 37:17)?
- Understand:* Zedekiah kept asking for God's word. Why do you think he never acted on it?
- Apply:* Is there something God has already made clear to you that you are still hoping he will change? What would obedience look like?
- Apply:* Whose opinion do you fear most? How could you keep that fear from steering your choices this week?